his 14-day hunger strike, Wangchuk had warned that, without meaningful concessions, Ladakh could see "Gen-Z protests of the likes of Nepal and Bangladesh...the real cause is the frustration of six years of unemployment and unmet promises at every level". Soon, the peaceful demonstrations he had led till then took a violent turn. Wangchuk was arrested on September 26 under the stringent National Security Act—on charges of "inciting mob violence" through "provocative statements"—and shifted out to Jodhpur jail in Rajasthan.

Retrospectively, a sense of planned intent is being ascribed to the sequence of events. On September 27, Ladakh DGP S.D. Singh Jamwal said Wangchuk was being probed for alleged "Pakistan links". Questioning its very basis, Wangchuk's wife Gitanjali Angmo—instrumental in running their non-profit, the Himalayan Institute of Alternatives, Ladakh (HIAL)—says the "witch hunt" began four years ago, when Wangchuk started advocating for statehood and inclusion under the Sixth Schedule.

HIAL was stripped of its land over allegations of "deep-rooted corruption". Their other non-profit, Students' Educational and Cultural Movement of Ladakh (SECMOL)—which earned renown as the inspiration for the hit film *3 Idiots*—had its FCRA licence revoked. Wangchuk has insisted that SECMOL never took foreign contributions, only payments from UN and European agencies for services rendered, which he said were taxed in India.

GENESIS OF UNREST

When Ladakh was carved out of J&K, many residents, Wangchuk included, had welcomed the freedom it would bring from the fraught politics of Srinagar and Jammu. But within two years, that enthusiasm soured into anxiety, fuelled by the absence of democratic agency and avenues to voice dissent or articulate aspirations. Earlier, Ladakh sent four MLAs to the J&K assembly. Now, as a UT without a legislature, it has none. The role of its apex elected body, the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council (LAHDC), has been reduced to basic matters like roads, water and electricity. It faces elections in October, with the BJP hoping to retain the majority it won in Leh in 2020.



Wangchuk speaks to the media in Leh, Sept. 25

KEY DEMANDS

- **Statehood: Ladakh as a separate state**
- **Inclusion in Sixth Schedule: Constitutional safeguards through autonomous governance**
- **Jobs: Genuine reservation and employment opportunities for locals**
- **Land rights: Protection and allotment of land**
- **Central representation: Allotting two Lok Sabha seats instead of one**

Unlike Kashmir's 16,000 sq. km land area, Ladakh spans nearly 60,000 sq. km but is home to just 275,000 people, as per the 2011 Census. Locals fear demographic change, and with a Centre-appointed lieutenant governor controlling key appointments, administration and land use, many sense growing marginalisation, disempowerment and even cultural erosion. The torching of the LAHDC secretariat and BJP office on September 24 reflected popular anger over unmet promises from the 2020 election—a legislature and Sixth Schedule inclusion among them.

Today, the demands unite Ladakh's two divergent districts: Muslim-majority Kargil and Buddhist-dominated Leh. Together, civil society groups and political parties, barring the BJP, have rallied under the Leh Apex Body (LAB) and Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA). Seizing the moment on September 28, Rahul Gandhi, Opposition leader in the Lok Sabha, mounted a sharp attack on the Modi government. Accusing the BJP-RSS of undermining Ladakh, he backed statehood and Sixth Schedule. The Centre, on its part, had all along sought to ease the agitation through dialogue, but with little success—unless dilatoriness was an objective in itself.

DEEPENING STALEMATE

It was in May that a panel led by Union minister of state for home Nityanand Rai last met Ladakhi leaders to discuss their grievances. That yielded a few placatory steps: a continuous stay of 15 years was mandated for non-Ladakhis to get domicile status; reservations for Scheduled Tribes, who make up the majority, were raised from 45 to 84 per cent; 1,800 posts were advertised. But a few key demands stayed unmet—a Public Service Commission to speed up recruitment; two Lok Sabha seats instead of one; and genuine safeguards for locals in jobs, land rights, culture.

Statehood, Sixth Schedule, a say over projects that could harm the ecosystem—these found no mention. Wangchuk accused New Delhi of not seeking peace, preferring tactics that could "aggravate" the air. His warning that "Sonam Wangchuk in jail will be equally, if not more, problematic" threw the dialogue process into doubt—both the LAB and KDA have pulled out of a scheduled October 6 meeting with the home ministry, demanding a judicial inquiry into the deaths and withdrawal of cases against locals. On October 2, a magisterial probe was finally ordered.

The Centre's wariness stems from Ladakh's geopolitically delicate location, a border zone with China that saw a flashpoint in the 2020 Galwan clashes. National Conference leader Farooq Abdullah warns against an incriminatory approach to local leadership, saying "the void might be exploited". L-G Kavinder Gupta seemed to pay little heed, alleging a "foreign hand", a claim swiftly dismissed by the LAB. For the Centre, the collapse of talks signals a crisis. It may need a warmer touch. ■